

Introduction:

Strategic nonviolence is a disciplined set of tactics that does not resort to violence to bring about social change. It is essential to teach strategic nonviolence in Civic Education as it is used to empower individuals to advocate for justice in their communities. Strategic nonviolence is not passive but rather a morally grounded approach that encourages active broad participation. Nonviolence is more likely than violence to succeed when trying to achieve long term goals.

Overview:

CIRCLE's work supports the integration of strategic nonviolence into civic education because it emphasizes creating a positive, inclusive environment where students can practice democratic values, conflict resolution, and civic responsibility. CIRCLE's research shows that positive classroom climate (shared norms, respectful interactions, student-teacher trust) is essential for civic learning. Strategic nonviolence is embedded by:

1. **Establishing nonviolent norms:** promoting active listening skills, constructive feedback, and respectful disagreement
2. **Using nonviolent tactics in lessons:** teachings/simulations of boycotts, sit-ins, and public demonstrations to create space for change and disrupt unfair systems
3. **Addressing systemic inequities:** recognizing that formal education oftentimes reinforces marginalization and community-based nonviolence education can be used to bring about change

Some hands-on application ideas for teaching strategic nonviolence in civic education include:

1. **Curriculum Integration:** lessons on nonviolent history, tactics, and community organizing
2. **Role-playing and simulations:** students practice nonviolent conflict resolution in safe, structured settings
3. **Service-learning projects:** partnering with local organizations that use nonviolent strategies and allowing for students to see this and join

Does this framework serve the four non-negotiables?

- Does it strengthen statewide civics coherence and local implementation? **Yes**
 - Does it give families and students real power, not symbolic engagement? **Yes**
 - Does it lead to hands-on civic practice tied to real decisions? **Yes**
 - Does it build strategic nonviolence and leadership capacity that can be paid forward? **Yes**
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Why does teaching strategic nonviolence in civic education matter?

- Encourages democratic practices and engagement
- Builds critical thinking skills and moral reasoning

- Prepares students to be adaptive, innovative, and resilient to injustices
- Empowers marginalized groups (who may face systemic barriers) with strategies and tactics to combat injustice without fear
- Allows individuals to develop leadership, teamwork, and problem-solving skills
- Helps understand the ethical dimensions of social change

References Page

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